

**President and Fellows of Harvard College
Peabody Museum of Archaeology and Ethnology**

Translation and Interpretation

Author(s): Gianni Vattimo and Stefano Franchi

Source: *RES: Anthropology and Aesthetics*, No. 32 (Autumn, 1997), pp. 55-60

Published by: [President and Fellows of Harvard College](#) acting through the [Peabody Museum of Archaeology and Ethnology](#)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.org/stable/20166985>

Accessed: 11-03-2016 13:01 UTC

Your use of the JSTOR archive indicates your acceptance of the Terms & Conditions of Use, available at <http://www.jstor.org/page/info/about/policies/terms.jsp>

JSTOR is a not-for-profit service that helps scholars, researchers, and students discover, use, and build upon a wide range of content in a trusted digital archive. We use information technology and tools to increase productivity and facilitate new forms of scholarship. For more information about JSTOR, please contact support@jstor.org.



President and Fellows of Harvard College and Peabody Museum of Archaeology and Ethnology are collaborating with JSTOR to digitize, preserve and extend access to *RES: Anthropology and Aesthetics*.

<http://www.jstor.org>

Translation and interpretation

GIANNI VATTIMO

A novel consideration of the phenomenon of translation is certainly one of the effects of hermeneutics. We may even say that hermeneutics has contributed to substantially reducing the importance of, or the emphasis on, the problem of translation, to the point that, when considered from a hermeneutic philosophical stance, the problem seems to disappear. At the same time, however, it seems that the scope of the problem of translation has been so enormously broadened that it coincides with the very problem of interpretation. As Gadamer writes in *Truth and Method*, "the conditions of the translator and of the interpreter are substantially the same."¹ Indeed, each interpretation is a transposition of the text into the language of the interpreter, regardless of whether the interpreter is dealing with a different historical-natural language or with a specific usage of the same historical-natural language of the text. It is only a matter, perhaps, of different degrees of distance from the text, but there are no essential differences in the philosophical meaning of these two operations. Moreover, in the case of translation, one supposes that the interpreter/translator must "own" the language into which the text is written (otherwise the translation could not even begin), that is, one supposes this language to be "her" language, and "hers" as well is the usage of the mother tongue into which any message must be translated in order to be understood.

The final destination of translation seems to constitute an essential difference from interpretation; in the former case, in fact, the new text is as "public" as the original, as it happens in the case of the publication of a translation of a book originally published in a different language. However, this instance might be assimilated to the public execution of a musical work, which is otherwise inaccessible to everyone unable to read the score, as a text written in a foreign language is inaccessible to everyone who does not know it. It does not seem that the public features of the translation, as well as of the musical execution, would substantially alter the situation. It is true that, in this case, the language into which the text is translated is not just the specific language of a single interpreter, but rather the

language owned by a linguistic community, and this is why translation is not generally considered a species of the genus interpretation. Nonetheless, the language specific to the single interpreter who reads and understands a text written in her own mother tongue is still the language of a linguistic community before it can become that particular declination of it that is specific to that single reader.

If these observations are granted—and we could discuss them in more detail without, however, invalidating the substantial identity between translation and interpretation—then a philosophy of translation can exist only as a philosophy of interpretation. This would not constitute a great advance, if the philosophical hermeneutic inaugurated by Heidegger had not deeply changed the concept of interpretation and cleared many of the misunderstandings that make up what we usually label the problem of interpretation. The hermeneutics derived from Heidegger has modified the traditional concept of interpretation in two ways: it has assumed that interpretations are constitutive of a text; and it has dissolved the illusion of originality of the text itself, because the text is not only co-constituted by its interpretations, but it is indeed an interpretation since its "origin." Hegel describes a similar situation in the *Lectures on Aesthetics* when he speaks of the relationship between the work of art and its public; the effort to embrace the point of view of the original reader is pointless, especially because the work of art itself was born at a distance from the facts, the heroes, and the events it refers to. "The homeric poems, for example, and regardless of whether Homer was the only author of the *Iliad* and the *Odyssey*, whether he really lived or not, the homeric poems are four centuries apart from the war of Troy; the great tragic poets were twice as long apart from the epoch of the ancient heroes, from whom they took the content of their poetry to transport it into their time. . . ."² Regardless of Hegel's intentions in this passage, his example shows that interpretation, and translation as well, cannot be thought as the effort to "reconstruct" the original, because there is no absolutely first original; the original itself was born already at a

1. *Wahrheit und Methode* (Tübingen: Mohr, 1960), p. 364.

2. *Vorlesungen über die Aesthetik*, in *Werke in 20 Bänden* (Frankfurt: Suhrkamp, 1970), pp. 341ff.

distance. This is why even if we could reach the original text in its initial identity, we would be disappointed by its poverty: "With the full knowledge of the origin its insignificance increases," as Nietzsche wrote in *Daybreak*.³ Not only are the homeric poems are not so original as we would like to think; but the richness of the meanings they convey to us has grown, over the centuries, adding onto an initial base that, besides not being really original, is also much poorer than its current form.

Therefore, interpretation and translation cannot be considered as mere transpositions of a content, given once and for all, to another "medium," be it the spirituality of the interpreter and/or the language of a different historic community. Translation is not, as the word would have it, the transfer of something that would keep its identity in spite of being moved to different "locations."

The dramatic importance often attributed to the problem of translation shows that even outside of hermeneutics there is an acute awareness that translation cannot be thought of in terms of "transfer." The spirit of a text, and especially of a poetic text, seems to be inextricably tied to the text's body, that is, to the words into which the spirit is fixed and through which it is transmitted. However, the issue is unsolvable unless one recognizes the "insignificance of the origin," in the double sense mentioned above, because the text to be translated seems such a compact and monolithic entity that it forecloses, tendentially, any access. An "object" thus defined and endowed with such a definitive identity cannot be translated without, inevitably, also being "betrayed."

A consideration of this aporetic situation should lead to a more serious consideration of the hermeneutic position. The insignificance of the origin dissolves the fetish of identity that has always grounded the objectivistic mentality of what Heidegger calls metaphysics. The fetish permeates both the positivistic historiographism (with its ideal of a perfect reconstruction of the text or of the event) and a certain classicism, inspired by idealism, that considers at least some texts (and poetic texts especially) as untranslatable because of their "absolute" status, a status that is guaranteed by the perfect identification of content with form.

But then, is it true that "*mes vers ont le sens qu'ont leur prête*,"⁴ as Valéry said in a famous line that even Gadamer considers the expression of an unacceptable hermeneutic nihilism? One should rather say, "*mes vers ont le sens qu'ont leur à prêté*." This reformulation (or translation) represents the only possible way out of hermeneutic nihilism that does not fall back into the aporetic structure of untranslatability. The faithfulness of an interpretation and of a translation is measured against a text that is not the fetish of a work accomplished once and for all, that is, an object endowed with a strong identity that makes it untranslatable. Yet, the text does not disappear into the arbitrariness of readings that turn it, each time, into something completely new. If the fetish of the irreproducible *hic et nunc* of the origin does not exist anymore, it is certainly not substituted by the alleged *hic et nunc* of the interpreter.

The text, as the etymology suggests, is a texture that connects the (almost insignificant) origin and its *Wirkung*—for example, the history of its interpretations/translations—into a network laid out in time. The emphasis on untranslatability arises when the effort to bring together these two aspects—the text accomplished once and for all and the interpreter/translator in her present actuality—does not consider their respective histories and takes them, consequently, as intangible absolutes. The insistence on the historical fabric within which the text and the interpreter are always already connected implies, in the first instance, that the truth of a text is only the truth that has been handed down; but it also entails that this truth can come to pass as truth only for an interpreter who does not consider it an object to be looked at (or translated) with the maximum of objectivity, but rather considers herself as a moment of the text's history.

This remark is essential, because otherwise the hermeneutic understanding of the text as the fabric of its interpretations would fall into the same contradictions that bog down the fetish of unrepeatable identity. If the frame of an objectivistic historiographism is not broken, even the text considered as the ensemble of its origin and its *Wirkungsgeschichte* will appear as an unreachable object. In short, from the hermeneutic standpoint, the interpreter not only translates a text laden with traces of the previous interpretations-

3. *Morgenrote*, section 44, in *Werke*, ed. K. Schlechta (Munich: Hanser, 1969), vol. 1, p. 1044.

4. *Variete III Commentaires de Charmes*, in *Oeuvres* (Paris: Pleiade), vol. 1, p. 1509.

translations, but she also translates *herself* into (the translating of) the text.

Thus there is a double path that can lead us out of the fetishism of absolute identity without vanishing into the arbitrariness of hermeneutic nihilism: on the one hand, the identity of the text, far from disappearing, has only become a diachronic "identity" (and perhaps one should call it a "family resemblance") that grows richer and richer during the text's history; on the other hand, such an identity can be grasped only by the gaze of an interpreter who places herself "responsibly" within the history of the text and who, moreover, allows her interpretative work to be caught into the play of the interpretations. For instance, the interpreter may recognize and make explicit the determined historicity of her interpretation and translation. What Heidegger says in *Sein und Zeit* about the existential characteristics of *Befindlichkeit* is also and especially valid when applied to translation: *Dasein* experiences the world always from an attunement, without which there would not even be a difference between foreground and background.

Indeed, the understanding of translation disciplined by the fetish of the strong and definitive identity of the text has never overcome hermeneutic nihilism. On the contrary, it has always been nihilism's condition of possibility, in the same way in which the conception of truth as mirroring has always been shadowed by skepticism and relativism. Far from opening the flanks to interpretative nihilism, hermeneutics fights against it by placing the text and the interpreter in a concrete historical relationship. One must acknowledge that the fetishistic belief in the independent objectivity of the text cannot constitute the ground for a concrete philosophy of translation.

Thus hermeneutics replaces this ideological conviction with the idea that the reality of a text is constituted by the "original" formulation plus the interpretations that have been added to it during its transmission. One cannot avoid the textual legacy, because the "original" text can only be reached by passing through it. The interpretative tradition may not be necessarily univocal. Still, we must consider the choices offered to the interpreter by that very tradition as fully belonging to it. Even the choice to go back to the "original" text by leaving aside the historical commentaries—a choice that sometimes determines a decisive renewal of the interpretation—can only be placed within the historical legacy of a text: first,

because the decision to go back to the plain text is never directed by a mere desire for objectivity, but it is rather inspired by a specific phase of the history of the text (even if whoever is responsible for the decision believes the contrary to be true); second, because the decision to go back to the "text itself" can only gain access to a text received from a historical tradition that is never a mere "transfer."

From the point of view of hermeneutics that I am illustrating here, the "betrayal" that is commonly associated with translation is therefore inseparable from the very idea of interpretation and translation, and it constitutes indeed one of its natural components. Translation does not simply make the text accessible to those who do not understand the language; it is impossible to translate without adding new meanings to the text. These meanings become encrusted upon the text and begin to be part of it as its organic developments. In fact, we may understand this process by using the image of the growing process of a living organism. The organism maintains its identity, although it changes its material components, as a sort of genetic code that makes it always recognizable. It is possible that during the process certain aspects of the original may be lost; it is precisely what often happens during translation and what suggests the ideas of untranslatability and "betrayal." However, the historicity of the text does not consist only in its capacity of growing through the interpretations and translations; the text can also get thinner and thinner, and it can lose one connotation or another, without becoming totally unrecognizable.

We are faced, once again, with the opposition between metaphysical objectivism and hermeneutic ontology. In spite of all its alleged fidelity to experience and to "reality," metaphysical objectivism renders unthinkable the phenomenon of translation and, more generally, the problem of the historical life of a text. Thus it cannot but motivate a preference for hermeneutic ontology and its rejection of the dogma of the origin. If one admits the insignificance of the origin, then one of its consequences is that the historical life of a text may entail the loss of some of its aspects; the text may become different but it is still recognizable (as it is proved by the experience of the historical fortune of the classics). The text is not completed and accomplished when the author delivers it to someone (for example, to the press, to the literary executor, and so on) as finished. The text itself is, indeed, a historical action that we can

certainly consider as "completed," but the action can only acquire its physiognomy from the effects that it produces in the course of its successive history.

The transposition of a text into another language is precisely one of these effects. An ideally complete recognition of the meaning of a text would have to take into account the transformations of the "original" meaning in the actual translations of the text. In the field I am most familiar with, philosophy, it is rather common to try to understand a classical, difficult, remote text by consulting its translations into other languages. Notice, however, that an "ideally complete" reconstruction cannot mean, given our premises, an "objective" reconstruction of the totality of the text along with its translations and interpretations. Translation and interpretation are always characterized by what Gadamer—borrowing a term used by judges and by the exegetes of the Scriptures—calls "application." If the fetish of the original must be left aside, the same is true for the fetishistic ideal of the integral reconstruction of the text and the history of its effects once it is considered as the historically becoming organism comprising the text and the history of its effects. Translation, like the historically concrete application of a law or of the Scripture, is always a risky decision that respects the text not because it grants it the aura of an unapproachable holiness, but rather because it assumes the text as a living appeal and answers it with a living gesture. Of course, judges ground their sentences on jurisprudence, and theologians and preachers read and interpret the Scriptures in the effort to find examples and clues in the religious experiences of the past. However, they do not reproduce the objective truth of the original text, nor the totality of its history. Rather, they try to grasp its sense in relationship to a specific situation.

As with morals, in the case of translation we always prefer rigorous and clear rules also (and perhaps especially) when we know perfectly well that they cannot be applied. It is certainly easier to imagine the objectivity of a text to which the validity of a translation or interpretation must be measured up, than to try to understand the historic life of a text and its capacity to grow and change itself during the course of its history. Perhaps the introduction of computers—leaving aside any temptation to follow the fashion—can help us understand better this capacity. It is now possible—and it will pose quite a few problems for the law on copyright and for the very concept of identity—to write

texts that are edited on a computer network and become available to others who can comment, modify, and reformulate them. I am not fancying a generalization of the surrealist game of *cadavres exquis*, nor do I think that we should go back to the myth of automatic writing. I am just suggesting that the issue of a text that remains identical while growing and changing through its "applications" is nowadays particularly urgent if we only think of these new opportunities opened by technology.

Indeed, it is not by chance that I mentioned computers and information technology. Because hermeneutics, as I tried to show elsewhere, cannot be legitimated, by definition, as the objective mirroring of the true order of being; it justifies its validity by presenting itself as the most reasonable interpretation of contemporary life. I think we might call hermeneutics an "ontology of actuality" by using an expression coined by the later Foucault, with a different sense (for example, interpreting . . .). A hermeneutic philosophy of translation must also recognize its dependence on a certain historical situation. The idea that translation and interpretation fully belong to the life of the text and constitute it, seems unthinkable outside the horizon of modern historical consciousness, before the birth of cultural anthropology or even before Freud and psychoanalysis. The dictum of eighteenth-century hermeneutics, which said that the text must be understood as well as the author understood it and then even better, was obviously unaware of the Freudian theory of the unconscious. However, it becomes even more fully "true" since this theory, rather than the reality of unconscious, has taught us that consciousness is not the ultimate instance and has therefore contributed decisively to the dissolution of the fetishism of the origin. On the other hand, ethnology and cultural anthropology (which are modern sciences and sciences of modern "objects" as well, since the latter have become recognizable as such only in the last centuries) have confronted us with instances of mutual translations and interpretations of cultures that are clearly not mere transfers of the same content into different linguistic forms. Yet, far from being betrayals and falsifications, such interpretations and translations are the true life of civilization. In short, I claim that a hermeneutic conception of translation-betrayal seems possible only within the modern pluralistic cultural world. Information technology belongs (to an extent that we are still

learning to assess) to this horizon, and this is why the mention of computers and computer network is not accidental here.

The possibility of thinking of translation (and interpretation before it) as an ontologically productive event (that is, as an addition of being) is granted, in the last instance, only within a civilization for which *contaminatio*, in the Latin sense of the term, has become the rule. This is why, perhaps, the problem of translation, as I said above, does not appear as a problem any more. For example, a few years ago, the French Government attempted to launch a campaign directed toward the purification of French language from anglicisms (the infamous *franglais*). Even leaving aside the possible objections to the chauvinistic character of a campaign that brings to mind the foolish efforts of Italian fascism fifty years ago, it must be noticed that the campaign has proved useless, and it has long since been abandoned. It was not necessarily a “rightist” crusade, and it might have appeared legitimate from the standpoint of the preservation of the identity of different cultures. Nowadays, this standpoint inspires ecologists and communitarian thinkers—often politically leaning to the “left”—who have an extremely negative attitude towards the destructions provoked by neocapitalistic consumerism, the last and most dangerous form of Western imperialism.

The issue raised by the binomium couple “translation-betrayal” becomes a true philosophical problem when it is linked to these debates concerning the very meaning of modern civilization. The issue is not to determine if, and to which extent, a text can be separated from a linguistic form and transferred into another. Such an issue can become a crucial and dramatic problem only for a philosophy that sees itself as an explanation of the mechanics of signification—a problem that we better leave to psychologists, biologists and linguists to solve. A philosophy conceived as ontology of actuality, as a search for the sense of being in our current existence, is interested in translation only in relation to what translation has become in the modern world. Here, *contaminatio* seems the most adequate word to lead our thoughts. Worries about the purity of the different national languages seem unrealistic, since they think they are dealing with a world containing truly national languages, each bearing a radically different understanding of the world that would give rise to real problems of untranslatability. When not unrealistically

naive, such preoccupations become philosophically unacceptable insofar as they take as their duty to preserve the identity of these languages against a process of contamination that they consider as a corruption and as a loss. Yet, at least within the confines of the Western *oecumene*—whose boundaries, however, are constantly expanding, following the diffusion of American technology and way of life—there is nothing like the radical diversity of languages imagined by Romantic thinkers like Herder. When we talk philosophically about translation, we must acknowledge that we live in a world where cultural identities have already been dissolved, for the most part, in a kind of common *lingua franca*.

Hermeneutics is the philosophy of this world, in the subjective as well as in the objective sense of the genitive; it interprets this world of contamination by both reflecting upon it and by being an expression of it. In the latter sense, as a product of the contamination it tries to theorize about, hermeneutics is a suspect thought; it seems unable to look critically at contamination, and therefore it may privilege the positive aspect of increase of productivity reached through combination, while losing sight of the negative sense that is already prevalent in the Latin word. Is it possible, in other words, to think of contamination only as a positive phenomenon of increase of being, while leaving aside what the word itself suggests and that which we can easily retrieve in our own experience of modernity? Will we encounter again the phenomenon of “betrayal” we tried to exorcise through an “annexation” that turned it into the possibility of felicitous and creative misunderstandings?

We can perhaps follow a spontaneous association and cite a line from *King Lear*—“Ripeness is all”—while keeping in mind the presumably melancholic tone that it carries in that text. Ripeness, or experience in general, has always, perhaps, the character of an unsettling and, initially at least, painful encounter: *pathei mathos*, learn by suffering, in the Greek of the tragic authors. Certainly, the *contaminatio* constitutes the natural path of the becoming of meanings in our world of translators-traitors. The recognition of this natural and physiological phenomenon helps to unveil the ideological delusions that lie hidden (nowadays, at least) behind any stress on the untranslatability of a text, on the strong identity of a language or of a text, and so on. However, contamination always carries with it a “dejective”

aspect, a component of loss and "betrayal." We do not know whether the loss of immediacy suffered by the text—the loss of the resonances tied to the personal psychology of the author or to the historical contingency of the contemporary reader—must be considered as a process of purification that elevates the text to a higher level of spirituality and universality, as Croce and Hegel, in different ways, would suggest. This explanation seems too optimistic and too close to a conception of being as process that is infallibly directed toward the accomplishment of fullness and positivity, that is, toward a full-blown presence. We cannot forget that contemporary hermeneutics, from which I take the lead for my considerations, is deeply inspired by Heidegger's existential analytics, in which being toward death plays an essential role. If we go back to the pages of *Sein und Zeit* where Heidegger deals with these issues—and not only in the first part, but also in the second, where the determinate anticipation of death constitutes the basis for authentic historicity—we will see that the ontological productivity of tradition is mainly tied to the succession of generations. Tradition is a betrayal positively constitutive of the text and not a renunciation or an alteration, and it is tied, if not to mortality, then certainly to the finitude of the interpreters. The original is enriched with new meanings by the plurality of interpreters and by the existential situations that the text enters into. It is of the essence, then, that there be a succession of generations and that each interpreter be authentically placed; without a specific, and therefore also "partial," point of view, without a qualified and therefore finite *Befindlichkeit*, there is no "application" of the text. There is no enrichment and no life either. The text is not a text any longer, but rather an "object" that can only be apprehended as *vergangen*, to use Heidegger's terminology, as a simple-presence characterized by its not being "possible" any longer.

We can build a whole discourse that respects the essentially nostalgic character of translation-transfer-betrayal (*tradurre-tradere-tradire*) around these pointers to finitude; therefore, no triumphs of idealistic coinage as we witness in Hegel (to a certain extent, at least, since there as well we see the labor of the negative) or in Croce (where this labor seems to diminish almost to the point of vanishing; history is the history of freedom). It is the "longing" for an original whose remembrance can never fully disappear in translations that keeps open the difference between text and translation (a declination, even the configuration itself of the ontological difference?)

and that, moreover, warrants the nondefinitive character of any interpretation or translation.

As we have seen, hermeneutic ontology, while de-emphasizing the problem of translation narrowly understood—its possibility allegedly threatened by the strong identity, at any given historical moment, of national languages, and so on—broadens, at the same time, the scope of the experience of translation-tradition-betrayal (*traduzione-traditio-tradimento*) to a general "law" of being itself. The contradictions of untranslatability can only be overcome, in theory at least (since in practice they have never existed, after all; texts have always been translated, more or less faithfully), within a philosophical perspective capable of renouncing the idea of being as full presence deployed once and for all—a philosophy that is ready, instead, to accept being as event, natality-mortality, difference, and longing.

Translated by Stefano Franchi.